HCP 1373 (pc_hcp_54): a Caesar-shifted love postcard of 4 November 1907

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

Status: whole message read, 63 of 63 enciphered letters decoded with a single key; independent review 1 verdict ACCEPT, no change to the decoded letters. Report dated 2026-10-30.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1373 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1373), portal name pc_hcp_54, part of the HCPortal collection of cryptographic postcards. When it was captured on 2026-10-30 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, tagged Postcard, HCPortal collection, category Substitution, date 1907-11-04, language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient "W. Abboú" (a catalogue spelling of Abbott), with no transcription or solution attached.

The picture side is a printed view, "Guildford Castle", with no handwriting. The address side carries a halfpenny Edward VII stamp and the postmark WIMBORNE / 10 PM / NO 4 / 07. It is addressed to Mr W. Abbott, Stokelake Farm, Chudleigh, S. Devon. The message is written sideways on the same side, so the scan must be turned 90° counter-clockwise to read it. 4 November 1907 was a Monday, which agrees with the plain heading "Monday".

The card belongs to a correspondence between one couple on the neighbouring HC Portal cards (hcp-1374 to 1385 from Wimborne, and hcp-1386 to 1407), in the same hand and with the same cipher. The heading number "No 1" fits "No. 3" on hcp-1376, dated Saturday 9 November. No published solution of this card was found or used.



Address side as scanned (source/address-large.jpg)



Message turned to reading position (work/reading.jpg)

Method

The transcription is manual, with no OCR. The un-converted original scan of the address side was turned upright and every row was read from crops enlarged 3 to 6 times. The couple's closing formula, known from sister cards, showed a shift of one letter at once: `Nz Pxo E. L. Cpz ... Gspn Zpvs Pxo E. L. Hjsm` decodes to "My own E. L. boy ... from your own E. L. girl". That is a hypothesis taken from the family, and it was then tested on every enciphered word of this card.

The last word of row 4 resisted longest. THANK, VITAL, TRIAL and other candidates were tried and rejected, because none has a crossed t in second place. The word was settled when the writer's t on hcp-1376 (in `qptufe` and `Nztufsz`) proved to be a tall stroke with a flag running right, the same as the second sign here. This gives V-t-v-b-m, USUAL.

The reproduction command, run from the repository root, checks the source hashes, decodes every token and checks the inverse:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1373/work/decode.py
```

Key

Caesar shift: each plaintext letter is written as the next letter of the alphabet. To decrypt, subtract one.

```
Cipher ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
Plain  ZABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXY
```

Not enciphered: the heading "G. H. Monday", "No 1", the word "Friday" in the body, and the "&". The groups `E. L.` (twice) and `N. & L.` are the couple's abbreviations, kept literal as on the sister cards. Their shifted values would be D. K. and M. & K.

Plaintext and translation

Row	Ciphertext	Literal plaintext
heading	G. H. Monday. No 1	plain writing
1	Nz. Pxo. E. L. Cpz.	MY. OWN. [E. L.] BOY.
2	J. bn. hpjoh. po.	I. AM. GOING. ON.
3	odjfmz. & bcpvu	NCIELY [= NICELY]. & ABOUT
4	Nz. Sppn. usz. Vtvbm	MY. ROOM. TRY. USUAL
5	gps. Friday. Nz. N. &	FOR. Friday. MY. [N. &
6	L. Gspn. Zpvs. Pxo. E. L.	L.] FROM. YOUR. OWN. [E. L.]
7	Hjsm	GIRL

The plaintext language is English. Punctuation in the readings below is editorial.

G. H. Monday. No. 1. My own E. L. boy. I am going on nicely & about my room. Try usual for Friday. My N. & L. from your own E. L. girl.

Slovak translation:

G. H. pondelok. Č. 1. Môj vlastný E. L. chlapec. Darí sa mi pekne a chodím po svojej izbe. Skús to obvyklé na piatok. Moje N. & L. od tvojho vlastného E. L. dievčaťa.

What remains uncertain

- `odjfmz` **= NCIELY, read as NICELY.** The signs stand in the order d, j, so the literal decode is NCIELY. This is taken as the writer's slip for `ojdfmz`. The decoder prints the literal form, and NICELY is an emendation.
- `Vtvbm` **= USUAL.** This is the hardest word on the card; the strokes are heavy and run together. A mark lost past the card edge cannot be fully excluded, but nothing suggests one.
- **Sense of "try usual for Friday".** The words are read, but the phrase is elliptical. It presumably refers to an arrangement known to the couple.
- **Sense of "about my room".** It is taken as "up and about in my room", that is, recovering. The card names no illness.
- `Nz` **in row 1.** The z is a short compressed stroke, weaker than on hcp-1376. MY here rests partly on the formula and on the fuller `Nz` of rows 4 and 5.
- **Abbreviations.** E. L., N. & L. and G. H. are not expanded, because nothing on the card proves an expansion.
- **Heading.** The first initial is printed G because of a small foot stroke, but C is not excluded and sister solutions divide. The sign after "No" is read as 1; an exclamation mark is possible.
- **Two deceptive shapes.** The P of Pxo (rows 1 and 6) has a very long flat bowl and looks like a T, but Txo is no word. The L opening row 6 has a top flag, unlike the plain L of `E. L.`

Review and what changed

An independent review was made by a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent. Solver and reviewer are the same model, so this was not a check across vendors. The reviewer re-ran the command, typed its own tokens from its own crops and decoded them with its own script, which gave the same 63 letters. It re-read every row and attempted to break NICELY and USUAL, and found that one shift covers all enciphered tokens. It also computed the weekday and checked the postmark and address. **Verdict: ACCEPT.**

There were four minor findings, all addressed, and no decoded letter changed:

1. The heading initial is now printed G, not C, with the doubt kept.
2. The description of the *z* in row 1 was weakened to what the scan shows.
3. The two deceptive shapes, P and flagged L, are now described.
4. USUAL is now flagged as the hardest word in the argument for correctness.

Credits

Transcription, decipherment and this report by Claude Opus 5.5 on 2026-10-30, using the cipher and hand comparisons from accepted sister cards. No earlier work on this number exists.